Articles / countable and uncountable nouns / quantifiers

Indefinite article

There are two indefinite articles in English: 'a' and 'an'. 'An' is used before vowel sounds.

Use	Example
Singular countable nouns (when we are not being specific or when we mention something for the first time)	*There's **a** good film on TV tonight.*

- Whether we use 'an' or 'a' depends on the sound, **not** the spelling.
  - ✓ *The news is on TV in **an** hour.*
  - ✗ ~~*The news is on TV in **a** hour.*~~
  - ✓ *Being in a film was **a** unique experience for me.*
  - ✗ ~~*Being in a film was **an** unique experience for me.*~~

Definite article

There is one definite article in English: 'the'.

Use	Example
Singular countable nouns (when we are being specific)	*Where's **the** DVD you were talking about?*
Singular countable nouns (when we are talking generally)	***The** radio seemed amazing to people at first.*
Plural countable nouns (when we are being specific)	*I didn't believe **the** rumours about the prime minister.*
Uncountable nouns (when we are being specific)	*I followed **the** advice my lawyer gave me.*

- The way we say 'the' changes depending on the sound at the start of the next word.
  Before a consonant sound (*the media, the USA, the programme*), we pronounce it /ðə/.
  Before a vowel sound (*the announcer, the actor, the editor*), we pronounce it /ðɪ/.
- We often use 'the' when we are talking about something there is only one of.
  - ✓ ***the** sky, **the** sun, **the** moon, **the** Prince of Wales, **the** North Pole, **the** World Cup*

Zero article

We often don't use an article at all. This is sometimes called the zero article.

Use	Example
Plural countable nouns (when we are talking generally)	*Journalists often face dangerous situations.*
Uncountable nouns (when we are talking generally)	*News travels fast these days.*

Articles in phrases and expressions

Notice how we use articles in the following phrases and expressions. Many of these are examples of general categories. For example, '***the** River Thames*' means that we use 'the' for all rivers.

Use	Example
Time	definite article: *in **the** 1990s, in (**the**) summer, in **the** morning* zero article: *in 2008, in June, on Friday, at night*
People and work	indefinite article: *have **a** job, work as **a** ...* definite article: ***the** queen, **the** principal, **the** president, **the** French* zero article: *become president, go to work, be at work, have work to do, he's French.*
Places	definite article: ***the** Alps, **the** Atlantic Ocean, **the** River Thames, **the** Earth, **the** Arctic, **the** USA, **the** UK, **the** Cyclades* zero article: *Mount Everest, Paris, America, Mars/Venus/Jupiter etc, Oxford Street, Lake Superior, Crete*
Entertainment and sport	definite article: ***the** media, on **the** radio, play **the** guitar, go to **the** cinema, watch (**the**) TV* zero article: *listen to music, on television, play tennis/football etc*

Use	Example
Organisations	definite article: ***the*** *army,* ***the*** *police,* ***the*** *fire brigade*
Education	definite article: *go to* ***the*** *school (as a visitor), be in* ***the*** *first year* zero article: *go to school (as a student), be in Class 3B, maths*
Travel	indefinite article: *take* ***a*** *taxi, catch* ***a/the*** *bus* definite article: *on* ***the*** *bus* zero article: *on foot, go home, go by bus*
Health	indefinite article: *have* ***a*** *cold/headache/cough* definite article: *have (****the****) flu/measles* zero article: *have toothache*
Public buildings	definite article: ***the*** *bank,* ***the*** *tax office, go to* ***the*** *hospital/prison (as a visitor)* zero article: *go to hospital/prison/church (as a patient/prisoner/worshipper)*

US vs UK Grammar

- Speakers of American English do not usually use *hospital* without an article.
  US: *The ambulance took Simon to* ***the*** *hospital.*
  UK: *The ambulance took Simon to hospital.*

Countable and uncountable nouns

Type	Example
Countable nouns ● Use *a, the, some, many* ● Use a singular or plural verb	*I want to be* ***a journalist****.* *Where is* ***the newspaper****?* *There are* ***some*** *good* ***articles*** *in the paper.* *How* ***many channels*** *do you get?*
Uncountable nouns ● Use *the, some, much* ● Use a singular verb	*Did you hear* ***the news****?* ***Some*** *important* ***news*** *has just come in.* *How* ***much information*** *do we have about it?* *Your* ***advice was*** *very useful.*
Common uncountable nouns: *advice, coffee, furniture, glass, hair, homework, information, knowledge, luggage, money, news, paper, work*	

Watch out!

- Most uncountable nouns are singular, but a few are plural. These include *clothes, scissors, jeans, spectacles, trousers, groceries,* etc. With these words, we use a plural verb.
  ✓ *Oh, no! My new clothes* ***are*** *dirty!*
- Some nouns are countable with one meaning and uncountable with another meaning.
  ✓ *Do you think you could bring me* ***a*** *clean* ***glass****?* (countable)
  ✓ *We should make computer monitors out of recycled* ***glass****.* (uncountable)

Quantifiers

Quantifier	Use	Example
many	● countable nouns, usually in negative statements and questions	*There aren't* ***many*** *programmes on TV that I find interesting.*
much	● uncountable nouns, usually in negative statements and questions	*My dad never shows* ***much*** *interest in the news.*
a lot of / lots of	● countable and uncountable nouns in positive statements	*That film has won* ***a lot of / lots of*** *awards.* *What* ***a lot of*** *luggage you've got!*
a few	● countable nouns, means 'some'	*There have been* ***a few*** *scandals in the papers recently.*
a little	● uncountable nouns, means 'some'	*They say that* ***a little*** *knowledge is a dangerous thing.*
few	● countable nouns, means 'not many'	*Richard has* ***few*** *interests outside work.*
little	● uncountable nouns, means 'not much'	*The police have* ***little*** *information about the robbery.*

Watch out!

- The phrase 'only a few' means 'not many'. The phrase 'only a little' means 'not much'.
  ✓ *There are* ***only a few*** *programmes on TV that I like watching.*
  ✓ *There's* ***only a little*** *sugar left, so get some when you go out.*

A Circle the correct word or phrase.

1 I love this time in **evening / the evening** when the sun is going down.
2 People play **cricket / the cricket** in South Africa, Australia and Sri Lanka.
3 It's too far to walk so I think I'll catch **bus / the bus**.
4 Jane had to go home from school because she had **a headache / the headache**.
5 The robber was sent to **prison / the prison** for a total of three years.
6 My cousin works as **waiter / a waiter** in a cafe near where we live.
7 The underground doesn't run this late so we'll have to take **a taxi / the taxi**.
8 I like to listen to **music / the music** in my free time.
9 My favourite subject at school is **chemistry / the chemistry**.
10 Jazz music appeared in America **in 1920s / in the 1920s**.

B Choose the correct answer. If no word is needed, choose 'D'.

1 Oh, I didn't tell you! We've got ..... new English teacher.
A a B an C the D *no word*

2 Here's ..... DVD you asked to borrow.
A a B an C the D *no word*

3 We're out of ..... coffee, so could you get some from the supermarket?
A a B an C the D *no word*

4 The prize is ..... unique opportunity to travel the world!
A a B an C the D *no word*

5 It looks like ..... glass in your bedroom window is cracked.
A a B an C the D *no word*

6 It's ..... honour to be here this evening to speak to you.
A a B an C the D *no word*

7 There's ..... good chance we'll be late for the meeting.
A a B an C the D *no word*

8 Reports are coming in of a major oil spill in ..... Mediterranean.
A a B an C the D *no word*

9 I went to see the doctor because I'm finding it difficult to sleep at ..... night.
A a B an C the D *no word*

10 Do you think that they'll ever send a manned mission to ..... Venus?
A a B an C the D *no word*

C Circle the extra word in each line.

Being in the news

1 The many people who appear in the news for the first time
2 find that a sudden fame has a negative effect on their lives.
3 The national press can be an unforgiving and the loss of
4 the privacy that comes with fame is an extra problem at a
5 difficult time. This is especially the case when a someone is
6 in the news because of a tragedy or the serious crime. Just
7 at the moment when you are under a most stress, you find
8 microphones and the cameras in your face. The media have
9 a responsibility to inform the public, but an innocent people
10 are often hurt by the demand for the scandal.

D Complete using the correct form of the verb in brackets.

1 The clothes you bought me for my birthday ..... (**be**) wonderful!
2 It turned out that the information we had received ..... (**be**) wrong.
3 My new jeans ..... (**be**) in the wash and I wanted to wear them tonight.
4 The luggage on a plane ..... (**take**) up a lot of room.
5 Your hair ..... (**look**) really nice and shiny.
6 I could tell by the look on her face that the news ..... (**not / be**) good.
7 Oh, no! My money ..... (**be**) in my other jacket!

E Find ten mistakes in this passage and correct them.

Newflash!

1 'We interrupt your usual schedule to bring you an important news. We are receiving
2 informations about a spaceship that has landed outside the White House. The large
3 ship seems to be made of glasses. Reports say that a short time ago aliens came out
4 of the craft. Eye-witnesses described them as short and said their clothes was made
5 of metal and their hairs was bright green. Strangely, one of them appeared to be
6 wearing a jean. Much people said that they seemed to be friendly. The President of the
7 United States is currently holding a meeting with the visitors in the hope that we can
8 exchange knowledges. Police advice are to stay indoors and under no circumstances
9 approach the spaceship. We will be back with another news as soon as we can. And
10 now, back to your usual programme, *Gardening for Beginners*.'

F Complete each second sentence using the word given, so that it has a similar meaning to the first sentence. Write between two and five words in each gap.

1 Not many people came to the party. **only**
There ..... people at the party.

2 The witness described the mugger to the police. **a**
The witness ..... of the mugger.

3 There isn't much sugar left. **a**
There ..... sugar left.

4 I am thinking of becoming a firefighter when I leave school. **brigade**
I am thinking of ..... when I leave school.

5 We were shocked by the news and didn't know what to do. **shocking**
The news ..... didn't know what to do.

6 There aren't many good films out at the moment. **only**
There ..... good films out at the moment.

7 I didn't eat much dessert because I'm on a diet. **only**
I ..... dessert because I'm on a diet.

8 You have lots of hats! **lot**
What ..... you have!

G Match to make sentences.

1 I'm quite busy so I've got .....
2 Happily, we have had .....
3 My dad just got a good job so we have .....
4 Pollution is improving now that .....
5 My mum has lost her job so we have .....
6 My lesson's been cancelled so I've got .....
7 It's a shame that .....
8 Unfortunately, we have had .....

A a little time to talk to you now.
B a few people recycle their rubbish.
C a few complaints from hotel guests recently.
D little money for luxuries.
E few people recycle their rubbish.
F very few complaints from hotel guests recently.
G a little money for luxuries.
H very little time to talk to you now.

H Choose the correct answer.

1 If you have ..... time at the end of the exam, check your answers.
A few B a few C little D a little

2 Give me ..... minutes and I'll be ready.
A few B a few C little D a little

3 We've only got ..... milk left so get some when you go shopping.
A few B a few C little D a little

4 Just ..... practice every day and you'll soon be able to play the piano.
A few B a few C little D a little

5 We were disappointed that ..... of the members came to the youth club party.
A few B a few C little D a little

6 Sprinkle ..... sugar on the strawberries.
A few B a few C little D a little

7 I suppose now I'm 43, I have ..... hope of playing football for England.
A few B a few C little D a little

8 Could you help me with ..... exercises I don't understand?
A few B a few C little D a little

9 There's ..... coffee left, if anyone wants some.
A few B a few C little D a little

10 Becoming an astronaut is so demanding that ..... people manage it.
A few B a few C little D a little

11 I'll meet you in half an hour - I've got ..... e-mails to write first.
A few B a few C little D a little

12 Many people feel there's ..... point in voting, even in a general election.
A few B a few C little D a little

I Write an article in each gap where necessary. If an article is not necessary, write a dash (–).

Ray: Hello?
Sandy: Hi. Is that Ray? It's (**1**) ..... Sandy.
Ray: Oh, hi! How was (**2**) ..... film?
Sandy: Great! We took (**3**) ..... taxi to (**4**) ..... cinema and (**5**) ..... taxi driver got lost, so we almost missed (**6**) ..... start. What about you? What did you do (**7**) ..... last night?
Ray: Oh, I just stayed at (**8**) ..... home. I listened to (**9**) ..... music for a while and then watched (**10**) ..... news.
Sandy: Oh, yes? So what's happening in (**11**) ..... world? Anything I should know about?
Ray: Well, I know you don't like (**12**) ..... politics, but there was (**13**) ..... interesting report on (**14**) ..... Asia. It gave me (**15**) ..... few ideas for (**16**) ..... geography essay we were talking about (**17**) ..... other day.
Sandy: Ah, right. Anything else?
Ray: Nothing important. Just that (**18**) ..... lead singer of your favourite band is getting married – to (**19**) ..... actress, (**20**) ..... one who was in that film ...
Sandy: What?! Why didn't you tell me? I have to check this out on (**21**) ..... Internet! See you at (**22**) ..... school tomorrow. Bye!
Ray: Okay. Bye.

J Rewrite the sentences correctly, adding articles where necessary.

1 We went to theatre last night and saw great play, although some of acting was bit poor.
.....

2 Give me ring tomorrow before I go to work and we'll arrange to meet at office.
.....

3 Prime minister told reporter that government wanted to pass law banning hunting.
.....

4 I asked hotel manager where pool was and she directed me to seventh floor.
.....

5 They said on news on radio that Mount Vesuvius, volcano that destroyed Pompeii, could erupt again.
.....

6 Car has revolutionised transport and is absolutely vital to economy of most countries.
.....

7 Judge read jury's verdict aloud and then sentenced accused to five years in prison.
.....

8 Job in media can be quite stressful because of pressure you are under to do things on time.
.....

9 Very few people in 19th century went to school or university and most started work at very young age.
.....

10 I have little free time since I gave up karate, so I'm thinking of trying new hobby, like learning musical instrument.
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